

CLASS - 12th

SUBJECT - ENGLISH

PROSE + POETRY + STORY OF ENGLISH

CLASS 12TH BIHAR BOARD – ENGLISH (RAINBOW PART 2)

POETRY CHAPTER 8: FIRE-HYMN (BY KEKI N. DARUWALLA)

 CHAPTER SUMMARY (IN 50 WORDS)

"Fire-Hymn" is a powerful and touching poem composed by Keki N. Daruwalla. The poet describes his experience at a burning ghat, witnessing the cruel and incomplete burning of human bodies. Belonging to the Parsi (Zoroastrian) religion, he reflects on his painful choice of cremating his first-born child against his tradition.

 12 IMPORTANT SHORT SUBJECTIVE QUESTIONS & ANSWERS

Q1. What did the poet see at the burning ghat in the early morning?

Ans: The poet, along with his father, saw the burning ghat glowing with red hot embers and half-burnt human fingers and bones, indicating that the fire had left its work incomplete.

Q2. What is the religious background of the poet, and how do they treat the dead?

Ans: The poet belongs to the Parsi (Zoroastrian) religion. Instead of burning or burying the dead, they place the dead bodies inside a structure called the "Tower of Silence" to be eaten by birds.

Q3. Why does the poet say that the fire is "cruel" and "forgets its dead"?

Ans: The poet says so because the fire sometimes leaves the human limbs and body parts half-burnt. Leaving parts unconsumed is seen as a disrespectful and cruel act by the fire.

Q4. What did the poet's father say to him while walking past the ghat?

Ans: His father pointed towards the half-burnt fingers and bone-shards, telling him that the fire sometimes forgets its dead and fails to consume the body completely.

Q5. What did the poet pledge or swear to do after his father's remark?

Ans: The poet swore a solemn oath to save the fire from the sin of forgetfulness by promising to always respect its power and maintain its sacredness.

Q6. What painful act did the poet have to commit twenty years ago?

Ans: Twenty years ago, the poet had to consign or sacrifice his first-born child to the flames of the fire because the nearest Tower of Silence was located a thousand miles away.



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Q7. Why was cremating his child a major internal conflict for the poet?

Ans: It was a major conflict because cremating a body goes completely against Parsi religious laws. He was forced by geographical distance to violate his ancestral tradition.

Q8. How did the fire respond or look at the poet after he cremated his child?

Ans: The fire looked at him with a gray ash-covered glow, and the poet felt that the fire was forgiving him for his forced religious rebellion.

Q9. What did the fire voice or say to the poet at the end of the poem?

Ans: The fire's roar or voice conveyed to the poet that he was forgiven for breaking his religious custom, and the fire swore to take away his guilt.

Q10. Who was Keki N. Daruwalla, and what awards did he receive?

Ans: Keki N. Daruwalla was a major Indo-Anglian poet who also served as a senior police officer. He received the Sahitya Akademi Award in 1984 and the Commonwealth Poetry Prize.

Q11. What is the meaning of the title "Fire-Hymn"?

Ans: A hymn is a religious song of praise. The title "Fire-Hymn" signifies a serious reflection on the pure, terrifying, yet sacred nature of fire as a consumer of human mortality.

Q12. What is the central message or theme of this poem?

Ans: The central theme is the inevitability of death, human helplessness under challenging geographical circumstances, and the sacred, purifying nature of fire across all human barriers.

© 35 OBJECTIVE QUESTIONS (QUESTION & OPTIONS IN SINGLE LINE)

1. 'Fire-Hymn' is a powerful and thought-provoking poem composed by: (A) Rupert Brooke (B) Keki N. Daruwalla (C) Kamala Das (D) D.H. Lawrence

2. Keki N. Daruwalla is a well-known _____ poet and short-story writer.: (A) American (B) British (C) Indo-Anglian / Indian (D) Nigerian

3. Keki N. Daruwalla received the prestigious Sahitya Akademi Award in the year: (A) 1950 (B) 1974 (C) 1984 (D) 1999

4. Besides being a poet, Keki N. Daruwalla served the nation as a senior officer in the: (A) Indian Army (B) Police Service (IPS) (C) Judiciary (D) Railway Service

5. The poem 'Fire-Hymn' primarily describes the scene of a: (A) beautiful garden (B) burning ghat / cremation ground (C) political meeting (D) war battlefield

6. "The burning ghat erupted _____ ": (A) smoke (B) phosphorescence / glow (C) water (D) gold

7. Wandering embers and ghosts lights frightened the casual: (A) soldiers (B) passers-by / travelers (C) doctors (D) children



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8. The sun sank into the sea, and the poet was walking with his: (A) mother (B) father (C) son (D) teacher
9. "The fire _____ its dead.": (A) loves (B) forgets (C) hates (D) rewards
10. The poet's father pointed out the half-burnt fingers and gray: (A) sand (B) bone-shards / ashes (C) water (D) wood
11. To a Parsi, leaving body parts half-burnt by the fire is considered a: (A) blessing (B) sin / cruelty (C) miracle (D) joke
12. The poet swore an oath to save the fire from the sin of: (A) anger (B) forgetfulness (C) greed (D) pride
13. The poet belongs to the Parsi religion, which is also known as: (A) Judaism (B) Zoroastrianism (C) Buddhism (D) Taoism
14. Parsis traditionally leave their dead bodies inside a structure called the: (A) Grave (B) Coffin (C) Tower of Silence (D) Pyre
15. Twenty years ago, the poet was forced to consign his _____ to the fire.: (A) father (B) first-born child (C) old friend (D) wife
16. The poet had to cremate his child because the Tower of Silence was a _____ miles away.: (A) hundred (B) thousand (C) ten (D) five
17. Cremating his child made the poet feel like a religious: (A) hero (B) rebel / sinner (C) master (D) saint
18. The fire hymn or the fire roar spoke to the poet and said: "I _____ you.": (A) punish (B) forgive (C) hate (D) ignore
19. At the end, the poet swears a second time, broken but: (A) rebellious (B) forgiven (C) angry (D) rich
20. The color of the ashes that cover the red hot embers is described as: (A) black (B) gray (C) white (D) red
21. The poem shows a deep conflict between human emotions and rigid religious: (A) laws / customs (B) books (C) finances (D) buildings
22. Daruwalla's imagery in this poem is highly vivid, realistic, and slightly: (A) humorous (B) gruesome / terrifying (C) romantic (D) comedic
23. The phrase "consigned to flames" means the act of: (A) burying (B) cremating / burning (C) drowning (D) flying
24. The poem highlights that fire treats all human bodies with absolute: (A) partiality (B) neutrality / indifference (C) love (D) anger
25. "Ashen swallowed up the red" indicates that the fire was turning into: (A) water (B) cold ash / dying out (C) a massive blaze (D) gold
26. The poet's fingers clenched into a fist because of internal: (A) joy (B) pain and determination (C) fear of darkness (D) laziness



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27. Important poetry volumes of Keki N. Daruwalla include 'Under Orion' and: (A) Leaves of Grass (B) Apparition in April (C) Peacock Pie (D) Songs and Sonnets
28. The language of the poem is solemn, heavy, and full of deep human: (A) comedy (B) tragedy and ethics (C) scientific data (D) business calculations
29. The term 'Ghat' refers specifically to a platform next to a: (A) school (B) river bank (C) railway station (D) desert
30. The fire took away the poet's sense of religious: (A) wealth (B) guilt / shame (C) joy (D) physical health
31. The poem displays that nature's forces like fire are grand and: (A) small (B) supreme / uncontrollable (C) artificial (D) weak
32. The father's role in the poem is that of a religious: (A) enemy (B) guide / pointer of reality (C) driver (D) critic
33. "Fire-Hymn" stands out as a unique piece in Indian-English writing due to its focus on: (A) rural politics (B) Parsi culture and rituals (C) industrialization (D) sports
34. The term 'embers' means small pieces of glowing _____ from a dying fire.: (A) wood / coal (B) water (C) leaves (D) clothes
35. The poem reminds us that absolute emergencies can force a human to break ancestral: (A) laws / traditions (B) bones (C) vehicles (D) records

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